



Rebuilding the Temple in the Midst of Opposition

Ezra-Nehemiah / Ezra 4:1–6:22

When I was 11-years old I built a dog house with a gabled roof. Two of the boys my age stopped by and asked me what I was doing. I had the rafters all lined up, but they had no boards attached yet. They held onto the rafters and they wobbled them back and forth. “Boy that doesn’t seem very strong to me,” one of them said.

My mother was teaching me how to build it. She was a very capable woman, and she had built roof trusses. She knew how to do it. After the two boys left, I ran inside and told my mother what they had said because I was worried I was doing something wrong. She said, “That’s how it’s done. It will be strong enough.”

Well, my dog would never go inside that doghouse. She wanted to be in the living room and lay on the rug. She wanted to be with people, not all alone in her doghouse.

Some little girls moved into the neighborhood and my mom talked to their mom. They decided the two sisters could have the doghouse as a playhouse. At least it would get used.

I rolled that doghouse from our yard to their yard. It was probably at least 300 - 500 feet. That roof was strong as it could be! It was like rolling a square barrel. It bumped and banged a lot, but it was sturdy and strong. Not one shingle fell off. Not one board was out of place.

There was no problem with that doghouse, but my friends had me convinced there was something wrong with it. Isn't amazing how a few words can shake our confidence?

We've read about the first year or so of the Temple's construction. Everything seemed to be going along quite well. But then there was a period of years where very little took place. In fact, it may have taken

as much as 20 years to build the temple from start to finish. The people's commitment to building the Temple was severely put to the test. It must have looked to the people like it was never going to be finished.

The biggest problem was that some people wrote about saying that the Temple should not be built. What people say can be a source of great encouragement, or it can be a source of defeat. Words can affect us both ways.

Why Did They Stop Building the Temple?

¹ Now when the adversaries of Judah and Benjamin heard that the returned exiles were building a temple to the LORD, the God of Israel, ² they approached Zerubbabel and the heads of fathers' houses and said to them, "Let us build with you, for we worship your God as you do, and we have been sacrificing to him ever since the days of Esarhaddon king of Assyria who brought us here." ³ But Zerubbabel, Jeshua, and the rest of the heads of fathers' houses in Israel said to them, "You have nothing to do with us in building a house to our God; but we alone will build to the LORD, the God of Israel, as King Cyrus the king of Persia has commanded us" ⁴ Then the people of the land discouraged the people of Judah and made them afraid to build ⁵ and bribed counselors against them to frustrate their purpose, all the days of Cyrus king of Persia, even until the reign of Darius king of Persia. ⁶ And in the reign of Ahasuerus, in the beginning of his reign, they wrote an accusation against the inhabitants of Judah and Jerusalem. Ezra 4:1–6 (ESV)

What gives it away is that these people who want to “help” are called “adversaries”.

Ezra 4:1 says:

“when the adversaries of Judah and Benjamin heard that the returned exiles were building a temple to the Lord”.

The original order from King Cyrus was only given to the people who returned.

“Whoever is among you of all his people, may his God be with him, and let him go up to Jerusalem, which is in Judah, and rebuild the house of the Lord, the God of Israel—he is the God who is in Jerusalem.” Ezra 1:3

These “adversaries” had been given instruction on how to worship the true God, but there is plenty of reason to believe they weren't getting it all right. A priest was sent to give them instruction so that they could obey God's Laws, but we don't whether many people followed his teaching. (2 Kings 17:24-28)

We read that the people of Judah were “discouraged” and “afraid” (Ezra 4:4). In addition, their “adversaries” paid bribes to officials to “frustrate their purpose” (Ezra 4:5). A letter was sent to King Osnappar (Ezra 4:10), persuaded him to order that the work be stopped.

Therefore make a decree that these men be made to cease, and that this city be not rebuilt, until a decree is made by me. (Ezra 4:21).

People must have been very discouraged. For about 15 years no progress was made on building the Temple, but then the people in Jerusalem started building the Temple again.

Why Did They Start Building the Temple Again?

The prophets Haggai and Zechariah came to Jerusalem and encouraged the people to start building again. The priest Zerubbabel listened to the prophets and order the building to begin again.

¹ Now the prophets, Haggai and Zechariah the son of Iddo, prophesied to the Jews who were in Judah and Jerusalem, in the name of the God of Israel who was over them. ² Then Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel and Jeshua the son of Jozadak arose and began to rebuild the house of God that is in Jerusalem, and the prophets of God were with them, supporting them. Ezra 5:1–2 (ESV)

As you would expect, the adversaries were not pleased. They wrote another letter

³ At the same time Tattenai the governor of the province Beyond the River and Shethar-bozenai and their associates came to them and spoke to them thus: "Who gave you a decree to build this house and to finish this structure?" Ezra 5:3 (ESV)

¹¹ And this was their reply to us: 'We are the servants of the God of heaven and earth, and we are rebuilding the house that was built many years ago, which a great king of Israel built and finished. Ezra 5:11 (ESV)

King Darius orders a search of the records be made to see if what the Jewish people said was true.

¹ Then Darius the king made a decree, and search was made in Babylonia, in the house of the archives where the documents were stored. Ezra 6:1 (ESV)

At long last, the records confirmed what the Jews had said, and things get much better.

Ezra 6:11–13 (ESV)

¹¹ Also I make a decree that if anyone alters this edict, a beam shall be pulled out of his house, and he shall be impaled on it, and his house shall be made a dunghill. ¹² May the God who has caused his name to dwell there overthrow any king or people who shall put out a hand to alter this, or to destroy this house of God that is in Jerusalem. I Darius make a decree; let it be done with all diligence." ¹³ Then, according to the word sent by Darius the king, Tattenai, the governor of the province Beyond the River, Shethar-bozenai, and their associates did with all diligence what Darius the king had ordered.

How many different kings and governors?

Nebuchadnezzar - took Judah into captivity

Cyrus - 539-530 BC

Darius I - 522-486 BC

Xerxes (Ahasuerus) - 485-465

Ataxerxes I -464/423

When Was It Finished?

Ended in 516 BC. Started in 536 BC. It took 20 years. Only the last 5 years were of uninterrupted construction of the temple.

What came next?

A lot of rising up and falling down, and then just before Jesus, the building of Herod's Temple

The New Temple and Jesus' Followers

God is building a new, eternal Temple.

[Ephesians 2:19-22](#) "So then you are no longer strangers and aliens, but you are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God, built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Christ Jesus himself being the cornerstone, in whom the whole structure, being joined together, grows into a holy temple in the Lord. In him you also are being built together into a dwelling place for God by the Spirit."

When will the new Temple be completed? Our hope.

The new Temple began being built with the incarnation of Jesus (John 2:19-22), and was fully underway at the crucifixion and resurrection. When Jesus returns the building of the new Temple will be complete (Revelation 21:10-16). The construction of the new Temple has been going on for 2000 years. There are times when believers get discouraged as the people in Ezra's time grew discouraged.

What part do believers play in building this new Temple? They are living stones.

⁴ As you come to him, a living stone rejected by men but in the sight of God chosen and precious, ⁵ you yourselves like living stones are being built up as a spiritual house, to be a holy priesthood, to offer spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ. 1 Peter 2:4-5 (ESV)

What should believers do to help build this new Temple? We are to encourage one another to grow in Jesus Christ, and be a growing part of His Temple. Notice what Paul wrote.

Therefore encourage one another and build one another up, just as you are doing. (1 Thessalonians 5:11)

Encouraging our brothers and sisters in Christ is not easy to do. Each of us has been born into a sinful world. Our natural inclination is to want to knock other people down; take them down a notch. We have a desire to teach other people a lesson when they disappoint us. Jesus teaches His followers to do something very different. If someone disappoints you, try to find some way to encourage them to do the right thing. That is how believers are to build up the new, eternal Temple that is the Body of Christ.

A final thought.

⁴ For whatever was written in former days was written for our instruction, that through endurance and through the encouragement of the Scriptures we might have hope. ⁵ May the God of endurance and encouragement grant you to live in such harmony with one another, in accord with Christ Jesus, ⁶ that together you may with one voice glorify the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ. ⁷ Therefore welcome one another as Christ has welcomed you, for the glory of God. (Romans 15:3-7)

The Jewish people in Ezra's time felt deep discouragement. They must have thought the Temple would never be built. By God's grace it was completed. God made it happen.

We may feel discouraged. We may feel that God's grace is being withheld from us. But in His time God will grant His grace to all believers. The Temple He is constructing now will be glorious and wonderful. Each believer will be part of that living, breathing Temple, alive with the presence of God. God will make it happen.

In the meantime, we should stay focused on Jesus. Remember what He taught His believers to do. When we feel tempted to tear down another believer, remember Jesus was beaten down. They killed Him. Do you want to drive a nail deeper into His hand? If you did want to drive one of the nails deeper into Jesus' hand then criticizing your brother or sister in Christ would be one way to do it. Tearing down our brother or sister in Jesus hurts the body of Christ. It hurts Jesus. Do you want to do what is pleasing to Jesus? Then lift up the brother or sister who has done something that hurt you. Show them the same love Jesus has shown to you. Forgive them as He forgave you. This is how we will build up the body of Christ. This is how we will build the eternal temple of the living God.

The Temple Finished and Dedicated (Ezra 6:13–18)

O S E N T Y P R O P H E T X H
R S R B L P T A T T E N A I A
D N S U I R A D S A U D N A G
E O R I U O F F E R E D O N G
R I E L B S Y H R T A E I E A
E S D D J P G O Z A S Y T Z I
D I L I G E N C E X S F A O T
E V E N K R I O C E O W C B H
H I P G E E D Y H R C U I - E
S D R V R D R P A X I R D R N
I S O R I U O R R E A L E A D
N G V E S R C I I S T E D H N
I B I V P I C E A U E A R T O
F G N I K B A S H O S R O E Y
D E C R E E Y T R H B S W H E
O L E V I T E S W E J I F S B

Then, according to the **word sent** by **Darius the king**, **Tattenai**, the **governor** of the **province Beyond the River**, **Shethar-bozenai**, and their **associates** did with all **diligence** what **Darius the king** had **ordered**. And the **elders** of the **Jews built** and **prospered** through the **prophesying** of **Haggai the prophet** and **Zechariah** the son of **Iddo**. They **finished** their **building** by **decree** of the God of **Israel** and by **decree** of **Cyrus** and **Darius** and **Artaxerxes king** of Persia; and this **house** was **finished** on the third day of the month of **Adar**, in the sixth year of the reign of **Darius the king**. And the people of **Israel**, the **priests** and the **Levites**, and the rest of the returned exiles, celebrated the **dedication** of this **house** of God with joy. They **offered** at the **dedication** of this **house** of God 100 bulls, 200 rams, 400 lambs, and as a sin **offering** for all **Israel** 12 male goats, **according** to the number of the tribes of **Israel**. And they set the **priests** in their **divisions** and the **Levites** in their **divisions**, for the service of God at Jerusalem, as it is written in the Book of Moses.

([ESV](#))

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